What are core beliefs?

Core beliefs shape how individuals perceive themselves, others, and their surroundings. These beliefs serve as a personal lens, influencing how people experience, feel, think, and behave in similar situations. A person can be in a similar situation but have different core beliefs.

Even if a core belief is inaccurate, it influences how a person sees the world around them. Core beliefs can be harmful--this leads to negative thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. Positive core beliefs can lead to more balanced reactions.

Situation: Two people with different core beliefs receive a bad grade on their test.

Person	Core belief	Reaction
A	"I am a failure."	**Thought:** I knew I would fail..why bother? **Feeling:** Depressed **Behavior:** Makes no changes.
B	"I am a perfectly capable when I put in my best effort."	**Thought:** I didn't do well because I didn't prepare. **Feeling:** Disappointed **Behavior:** Plans to study better.

Common unhelpful core beliefs

Self-related		World-related
"I am weak"	"I am unlovable"	"The world is dangerous"
"I am a loser"	"I am alone"	"I can't trust people"
"I am trapped"	"No one likes me"	"Nothing ever goes right"
"I am worthless"	"I am bad"	"I don't deserve to live"

Impacts of unhelpful core beliefs

Interpersonal problems

- Hard time trusting other people
- Feeling inadequate in relationships
- Overly jealous
- Aggressive and confrontational demeanor
- Prioritizing others over yourself

Mental health problems

- Depression
- Anxiety
- Abusing substances
- Difficulty handling stress
- Low self-esteem

Facts about core beliefs

- Core beliefs are things you are not born with, they are learned.
- Core beliefs usually develop in childhood, and adapted in adulthood.
- Negative core beliefs are not necessarily true, even if they feel like they are.
- Core beliefs can feel like they are rigid, but they can be changed.